

SESSION 3B

REALITY OF HEAVEN AND HELL

REALITY OF HEAVEN AND HELL



HEBREWS 9:27 (ESV)

27 And just as it is appointed for man to die once, and after that comes judgment



2 THESSALONIANS 1:9 (ESV)

9 They will suffer the punishment of eternal destruction, away from the presence of the Lord and from the glory of his might



MATTHEW 8:12 (ESV)

12 while the sons of the kingdom will be thrown into the outer darkness. In that place there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.



MATTHEW 22:13 (ESV)

13 Then the king said to the attendants, 'Bind him hand and foot and cast him into the outer darkness. In that place there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.'



MATTHEW 25:31, 41 (ESV)

31 When the Son of Man comes in his glory, and all the angels with him, then he will sit on his glorious throne.

...

41 Then he will say to those on his left, 'Depart from me, you cursed, into the eternal fire prepared for the devil and his angels.'



GALATIANS 6:7-8 (ESV)

7 Do not be deceived: God is not mocked, for whatever one sows, that will he also reap. 8 For the one who sows to his own flesh will from the flesh reap corruption, but the one who sows to the Spirit will from the Spirit reap eternal life.



LUKE 13:24-29 (ESV)

24 Strive to enter through the narrow door. For many, I tell you, will seek to enter and will not be able. 25 When once the master of the house has risen and shut the door, and you begin to stand outside and to knock at the door, saying, 'Lord, open to us,' then he will answer you, 'I do not know where you come from.' 26 Then you will begin to say, 'We ate and drank in your presence, and you taught in our streets.' 27 But he will say, 'I tell you, I do not know where you come from. Depart from me, all you workers of evil!' 28 In that place there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth, when you see Abraham and Isaac and Jacob and all the prophets in the kingdom of God but you yourselves cast out. 29 And people will come from east and west, and from north and south, and recline at table in the kingdom of God.



ROMANS 2:4–8 (ESV)

4 Or do you presume on the riches of his kindness and forbearance and patience, not knowing that God's kindness is meant to lead you to repentance? 5 But because of your hard and impenitent heart you are storing up wrath for yourself on the day of wrath when God's righteous judgment will be revealed. 6 He will render to each one according to his works: 7 to those who by patience in well-doing seek for glory and honor and immortality, he will give eternal life; 8 but for those who are self-seeking and do not obey the truth, but obey unrighteousness, there will be wrath and fury.



JOHN 5:24 (ESV)

24 Truly, truly, I say to you, whoever hears my word and believes him who sent me has eternal life. He does not come into judgment, but has passed from death to life.

We are all going to be somewhere eternally. As the above passages reveal, hell is that state of final separation from God. It is to be removed finally from the only source of goodness and light in the universe. Sin IS separation from God, and that state, unrepaired and continuing forever is hell.

But people don't want to think about hell. They get upset about the very idea. The modern man's sense of regality and entitlement finds such a thought offensive. They say, "How can you say, in this day and age, that there is hell, fire and brimstone?" These are not thoughtful responses. The words "damn" and "hell" are biblical words, and they refer to realities.

What is the alternative to hell? What is God supposed to do with human sin? Pretend it never happened? And everybody goes to heaven? And nothing anyone ever did really mattered in the end—the murderer and the saint, all in the same boat? Or, that we all get extinguished at death, that there is nothing beyond? People make up various views on judgment and the afterlife, but mostly it's guesswork based on their need for emotional comfort, not on any authoritative knowledge.

What ideas about judgment and the afterlife did you have before you became Christian? How did these ideas form?

THE TESTIMONY OF JESUS

Jesus is our authority on this subject. Jesus knows what he is talking about, and he talked about heaven and hell quite frequently. Many of his teachings emphasized the ultimate and eternal consequences of people's choices regarding him.

Here is a small sample:

- Parable of the Talents (Matthew 25)
- Sheep and the goats (Matthew 25)
- Parable of the Tenants (Matthew 21)
- Parable of the Dishonest Manager (Luke 16)
- Rich man and Lazarus (Luke 16)
- Parable of the Great Banquet (Luke 14)

Eternal judgment, and heaven and hell were among the top topics Jesus addressed during his ministry on earth. And as he was dying, he illustrated graphically the reality of the afterlife one final time.

As Jesus was dying on the cross, what he said to the criminal crucified next to him is highly significant. This most ethical person in whom not even his enemies could find a single moral flaw, whose teachings inspire down to this era – this is what Jesus said:



LUKE 23:39–43 (ESV)

39 One of the criminals who were hanged railed at him, saying, “Are you not the Christ? Save yourself and us!” 40 But the other rebuked him, saying, “Do you not fear God, since you are under the same sentence of condemnation? 41 And we indeed justly, for we are receiving the due reward of our deeds; but this man has done nothing wrong.” 42 And he said, “Jesus, remember me when you come into your kingdom.” 43 And he said to him, “Truly, I say to you, today you will be with me in Paradise.”

From a certain angle, it is an absurd scene between crucified criminals. One criminal rebukes the other criminal. “We’re sinners. We deserve this. This man has done nothing wrong. In fact, I believe He is the King of a kingdom.” Then turning to Jesus he says, “Jesus, remember me when you come into your kingdom.” And Jesus says, “Today you will be with me in Paradise.”

This is precisely why Jesus died on the cross and rose from the grave: to make a way for us to be with him forever.



JOHN 14:1–3 (ESV)

1 Let not your hearts be troubled. Believe in God; believe also in me. 2 In my Father’s house are many rooms. If it were not so, would I have told you that I go to prepare a place for you? 3 And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again and will take you to myself, that where I am you may be also.



JOHN 17:1-3, 24 (ESV)

1 When Jesus had spoken these words, he lifted up his eyes to heaven, and said, “Father, the hour has come; glorify your Son that the Son may glorify you, 2 since you have given him authority over all flesh, to give eternal life to all whom you have given him. 3 And this is eternal life, that they know you the only true God, and Jesus Christ whom you have sent.

...

24 Father, I desire that they also, whom you have given me, may be with me where I am, to see my glory that you have given me because you loved me before the foundation of the world.



2 CORINTHIANS 4:7, 16-18 (ESV)

7 But we have this treasure in jars of clay, to show that the surpassing power belongs to God and not to us.

...

16 So we do not lose heart. Though our outer self is wasting away, our inner self is being renewed day by day. 17 For this light momentary affliction is preparing for us an eternal weight of glory beyond all comparison, 18 as we look not to the things that are seen but to the things that are unseen. For the things that are seen are transient, but the things that are unseen are eternal.

How would you summarize Jesus' message regarding the afterlife?

DENIAL

There are some who, faced with a stark reality, simply ignore it. In other words, they choose not to think about something uncomfortable, hoping that by doing so it will just cease to exist. That is called denial.

Regarding heaven and hell, it sounds something like this: "Ah, it will probably be OK. It will be alright." But what is such a vague sense of wellbeing regarding your final destiny based on, we might ask? What makes you think it'll be alright? Did God speak to you? Did you have a near-death experience in which you went to heaven, and there was an angel who told you, "Hey, I looked you up in the book, and you'll be alright"? It turns out that it's not based on anything at all. Yet people think, "I probably won't die, at

least not for a while, so I don't have to think about it. But if I die, it'll probably be OK. There's probably no heaven and hell. And if there is heaven and hell, I'll probably get into heaven ... somehow." And that seems good enough for a lot of people. As crazy as this is, huge numbers of people in our world do something very similar to this. It is brute denial.

On the topic of our eternal destiny, there are not really that many options. The first option is that we are

no more than the molecules that comprise our bodies, and when we die that is the end. There is no self beyond death. The only other alternative is that we are more than our bodies. Our ability for abstract thought that has nothing to do with our senses, the fact that we can rise above our bodily instincts, that we have freedom to choose ... all these point to a self that transcends the material.

These are the two options. Clearly, we are more than our bodies. Our personhood is not constructed out of the physical. We have our bodies; we are not our bodies. Although most agree that we are more than our bodies, people just stop there. They may even go on to say, "There's got to be more to life than this." However, they rarely grapple with the pressing question that immediately follows--"What is the 'more'?" and "What is the ultimate destiny of the soul?"

There aren't that many true atheists in our world. Most are agnostic, and yet they think, "Ah, it'll probably be OK when I die, even if there turns out to be God after all." If you're agnostic, then it only makes sense for you to not rest until you settle these questions. Yet very few agnostics seem concerned to do so.

The immortality of the soul is something of such vital importance to us, affecting us so deeply, that one must have lost all feeling not to care about knowing the facts of the matter. All our actions and thoughts must follow such different paths, according to whether there is hope of eternal blessings or not, that the only possible way of acting with sense and judgment is to decide our course in the light of this point, which ought to be our ultimate objective. Thus our chief interest and chief duty is to seek enlightenment on this subject, on which all our conduct depends. And that is why, amongst those who are not convinced, I make an absolute distinction between those who strive with all their might to learn and those who live without troubling themselves or thinking about it.

- Blaise Pascal, *Pensees* ¹

¹ Pascal, Blaise. *Pensees*. New York: E.P. Dutton & Co., Inc.: 1958. p.427. Kindle edition

Please summarize Pascal's quote in 1-2 sentences.

Again, Pascal:

Being unable to cure death, wretchedness and ignorance, men have decided, in order to be happy, not to think about such things.

– Blaise Pascal, *Pensees*²

We run heedlessly into the abyss after putting something in front of us to stop us seeing it.

– Blaise Pascal, *Pensees*³

What is your response to the fact that people can be happy simply by choosing not to think about death and the question of what comes after?

LONGING FOR HEAVEN

There is a longing in each of us for eternity. As Ecclesiastes 3:11 states, "He has placed eternity into our hearts."

C.S. Lewis puts it this way:

The Christian says, "Creatures are not born with desires unless satisfaction for those desires exists. A baby feels hunger: well, there is such a thing as food. A duckling wants to swim: well, there is such a thing as water. Men feel sexual desire: well, there is such a thing as sex. If I find in myself a desire which no experience in this world can satisfy, the most probable explanation is that I was made for another world. If none of my earthly pleasures satisfy it, that does not prove that the universe is a fraud. Probably earthly pleasures were never meant to satisfy it, but only to arouse it, to suggest the real thing. If that is so, I must take care, on the one hand, never to despise, or be unthankful for, these earthly blessings, and on the other, never to mistake them for the something else of which they are only a kind of copy, or echo, or mirage. I must keep alive in myself the desire for my true country, which I shall not find till after death; I must never let it get snowed under or turned aside; I must make it the main object of life to press on to that other country and to help others to do the same."⁴

- C.S. Lewis, *Mere Christianity*

² Pascal, Blaise. *Pensees*. New York: E.P. Dutton & Co., Inc.: 1958. p. 133. Kindle edition.

³ Pascal, Blaise. *Pensees*. New York: E.P. Dutton & Co., Inc.: 1958. p. 166. Kindle edition.

⁴ Lewis, C.S. (2009-05-28). *Mere Christianity* (C.S. Lewis Signature Classics). HarperCollins. pp. 136-137. Kindle edition.

Related to this is another "signal of eternity," and that is our sense of nostalgia. When I first heard the song "Home on the Range" (lyrics below), I had a strong pang of longing that I could not quite place.



Oh, give me a home where the buffalo roam, where the deer and the antelope play, where seldom is heard a discouraging word, and the skies are not cloudy all day. Home, home on the range, where the deer and the antelope play.

– Dr. Brewster Higley (1876)

I've never had a home on the range, and the thought of buffaloes roaming is not pleasant to me. Yet, there was something that stirred within (and I suspect for countless others who have sung this old campfire song throughout the years). But if we have never lived in the prairies of the Midwest, what exactly is the song awakening? Whatever it is, it is NOT the actual experience of a home where buffalo, deer and antelope play. This, like other experiences of "beauty," awakens a longing but does not actually contain the substance of its satisfaction. The longing seems to be for something quite different than what triggered it. The fleeting joy came through but was not in the thing that triggered it. C.S. Lewis calls this "the inconsolable longing"—a yearning for heaven that gets triggered, if only in fleeting moments, through experiences of something like beauty.

For you, it might not be a silly song like "Home on the Range." It might be something else. It might be a piece of music. It might be a smell. A distant light as you drive along a long stretch of a country road at night. A picture of a sunset. Looking down at a valley full of tall pine trees. Coming up on a pristine meadow with a clear stream running through it. A line in a poem. Suddenly, you're transported to a memory that you don't actually have, a yearning for something almost familiar, like echoes from the distant country that shows us we're made for a truer home than we've ever known.

Here's a much more eloquent statement on the same topic from C.S. Lewis:

In speaking of this desire for our own far-off country, which we find in ourselves even now, I feel a certain shyness. ...I am trying to rip open the inconsolable secret in each one of you—the secret which hurts so much that you take your revenge on it by calling it names like Nostalgia and Romanticism and Adolescence...the secret we cannot hide and cannot tell, though we desire to do both. We cannot tell it because it is a desire for something that has never actually appeared in our experience. We cannot hide it because our experience is constantly suggesting it ... Our commonest expedient is to call it beauty and behave as if that had settled the matter. Wordsworth's expedient was to identify it with certain moments in his own past. But all this is a cheat. If Wordsworth had gone back to those moments in the past, he would not have found the thing itself, but only the reminder of it; what he remembered would turn out to be itself a remembering. The books or the music in which we thought the beauty was located will betray us if we trust to them; it was not in them, it only came through them, and what came through them was longing. These things—the beauty, the memory of our own past—are good images of what we really desire; but if they are mistaken for the thing itself they turn into dumb idols, breaking the hearts of their worshippers. For they are not the thing itself; they are only the scent of a flower we have not found, the echo of a tune we have not heard, news from a country we have never yet visited.⁵

- C.S. Lewis, *The Weight of Glory*

⁵ Lewis, C.S. *Weight of Glory*. New York: Macmillan, 1949. pp. 28-29.

COURSE 201 - CHAPTER 3 - HEAVEN AND HELL - Module 3B

The Bible describes us as exiles, banished from paradise. So we feel alienated, like we're not quite at home here. There's a restlessness that robs us of lasting enjoyment of anything on earth--toys or pleasures—that makes us perpetually discontent. All this points to the Bible's assertion: we've been made for a transcendent reality beyond this life. We are not only of the dust of the earth; we have been created by an eternal loving God in his image.

Are you familiar with the desire, which no experience in this world can satisfy? When is this desire most acutely felt?

How have you tried to satisfy "the inconsolable longing" but found the whole endeavor wanting?

SESSION 3B QUIZ

Complete this C.S. Lewis quote. One word fits all the blanks.

The Christian says, "Creatures are not born with _____ unless satisfaction for those _____ exists. [...] If I find in myself a _____ which no experience in this world can satisfy, the most probable explanation is that I was made for another world.